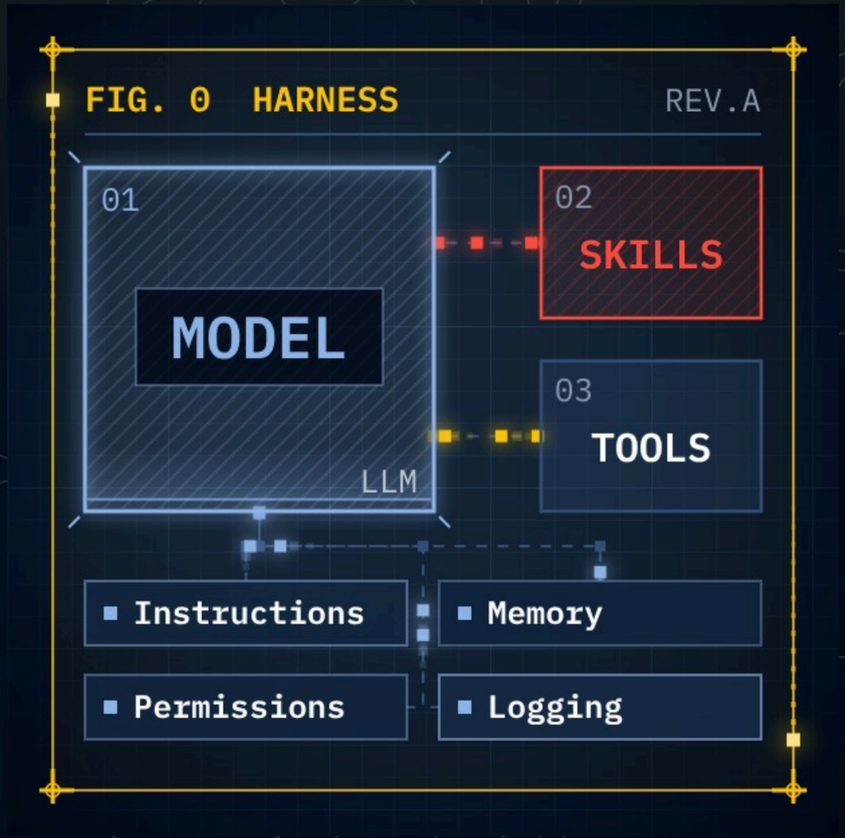
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TRAIN-THE-TRAINER SERIES · SESSION 1 OF 8

What an LLM is, and the types of harnesses

The model thinks. The harness decides what it can see and do.



11–minute video | Foundation · before Stage 1 | Guide Part 2.1

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TODAY

By the end, your learners can…

1. Explain what an LLM is, and is not
2. Name the parts of an AI system
3. Recognize the six types of harness
4. Tell a chatbot, workflow and agent apart

CHAPTERS · 11 MIN

drawn to scale



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WHY START HERE

Most confusion in AI briefings is about words, not technology

“

We use ChatGPT

usually names a whole system, not a model.

“

It’s an agent

is said of almost anything, usually a chatbot or fixed workflow.

“

The AI did it

credits the model for what the harness allowed.

The three most misused terms in the field:

AI safety | Agent | Workflow

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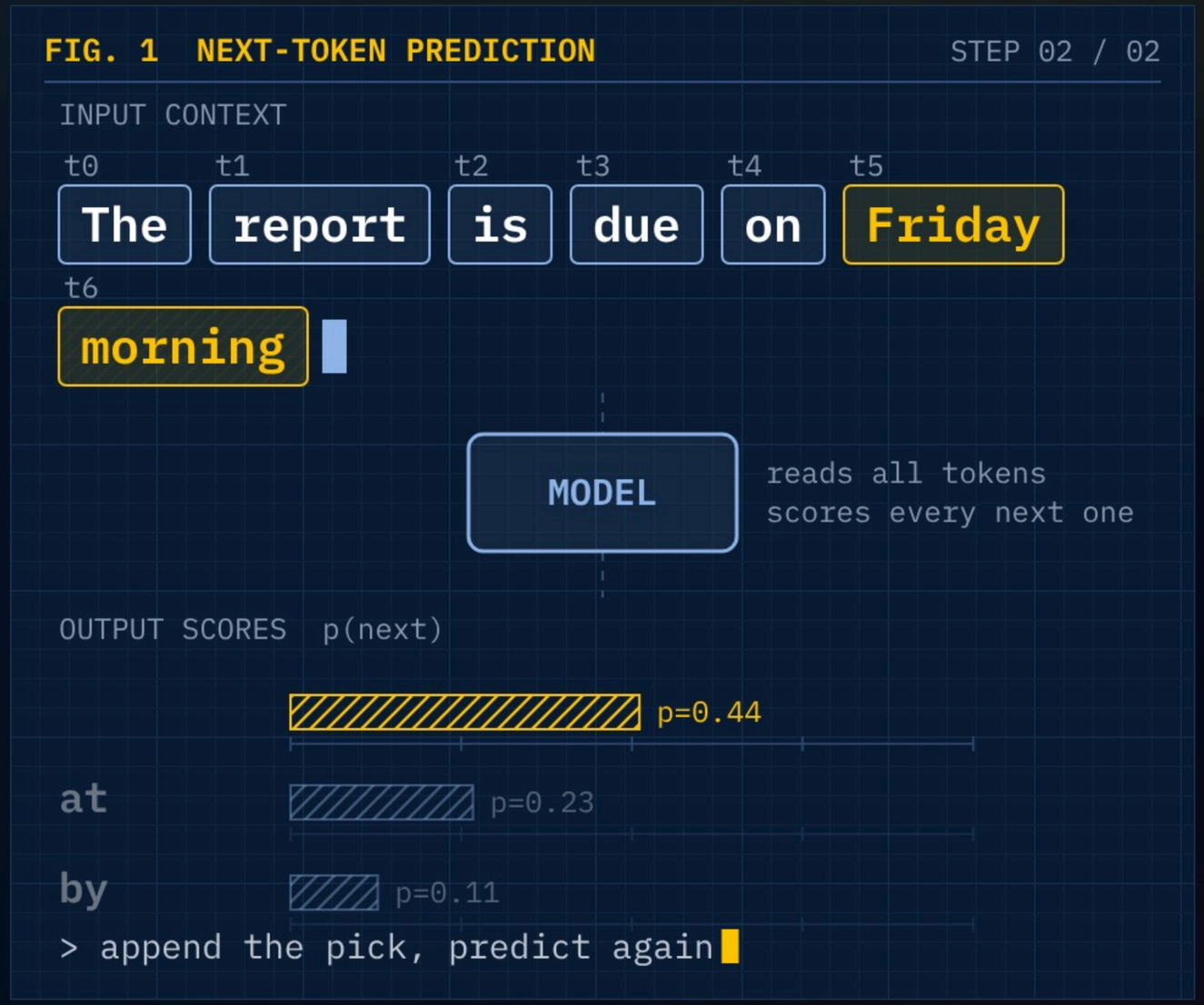
WHAT AN LLM IS

A trained engine that predicts the next piece of text, one token at a time

Large
Billions of learned settings (weights)

Language
Reads and writes tokens, about ¾ of a word

Model
The engine only, not the app around it

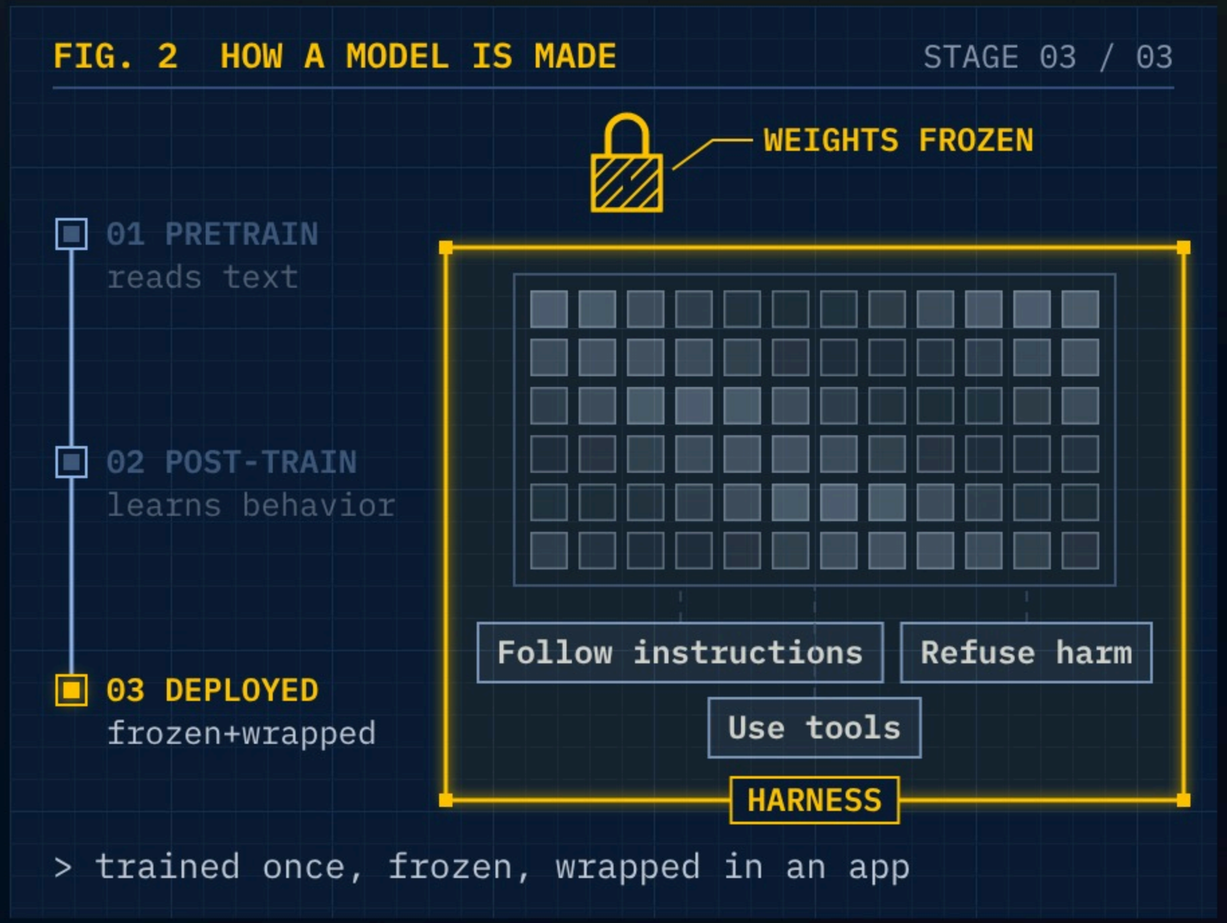


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HOW A MODEL IS MADE

Trained once, then frozen and wrapped in an app

- Has a knowledge cutoff
- Does not learn from your chats
- Current facts arrive only if fetched



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WHAT A MODEL IS NOT

Six beliefs to correct early

BELIEF

"It looks things up"

REALITY

It generates; it fetches only through a tool

BELIEF

"It learns from my chats"

REALITY

Weights are frozen; memory is the harness

BELIEF

"It knows today's news"

REALITY

Only up to its cutoff, plus what is fetched

BELIEF

"Same question, same answer"

REALITY

Output varies run to run

BELIEF

"Wrong answers are rare"

REALITY

Fluent errors are a normal failure

BELIEF

"Customizing means training"

REALITY

Prompts, skills and retrieval usually suffice

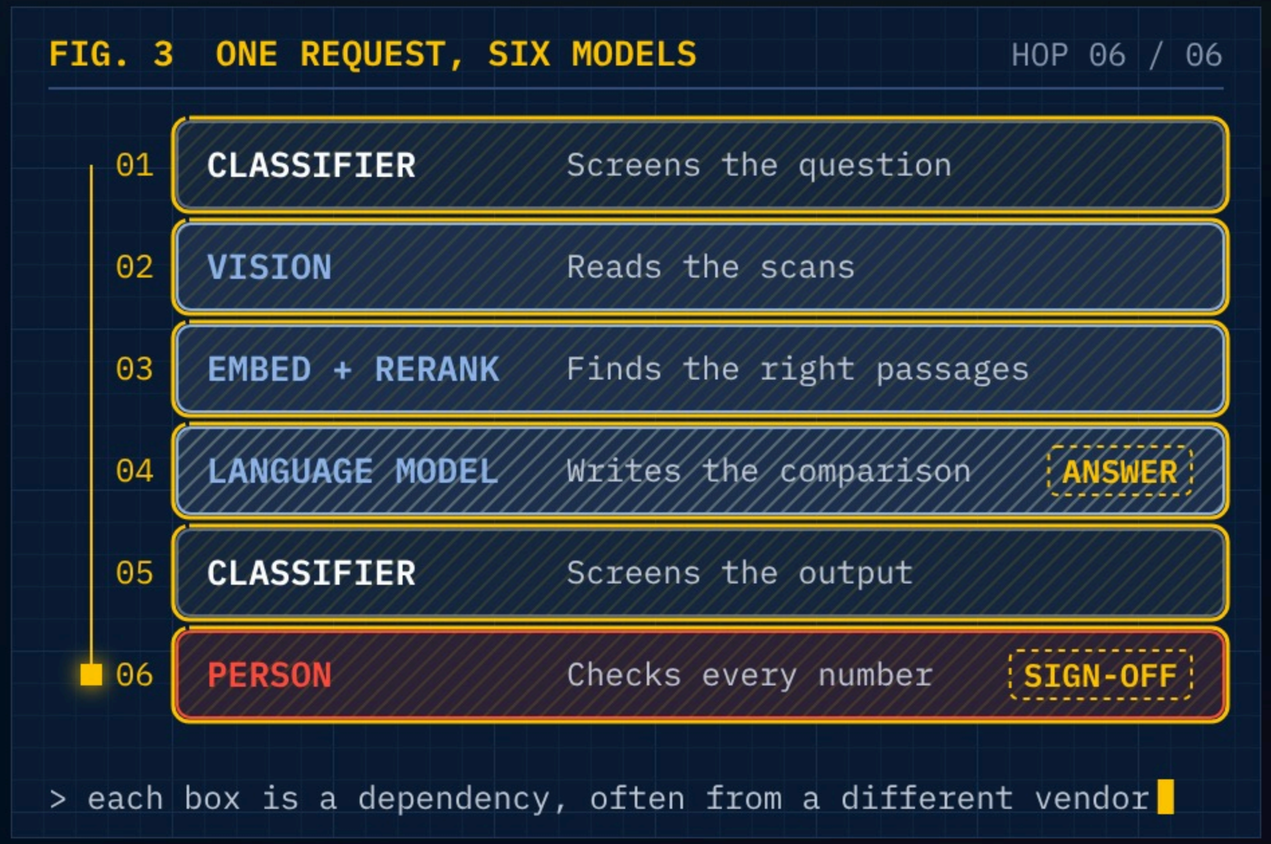
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NOT JUST LLMS

One request passes through several models

Example request:
“Review these scanned vendor proposals against last quarter’s scores.”

Each model is a dependency, often from a different vendor. The LLM writes near the end.



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THE RULE OF THUMB

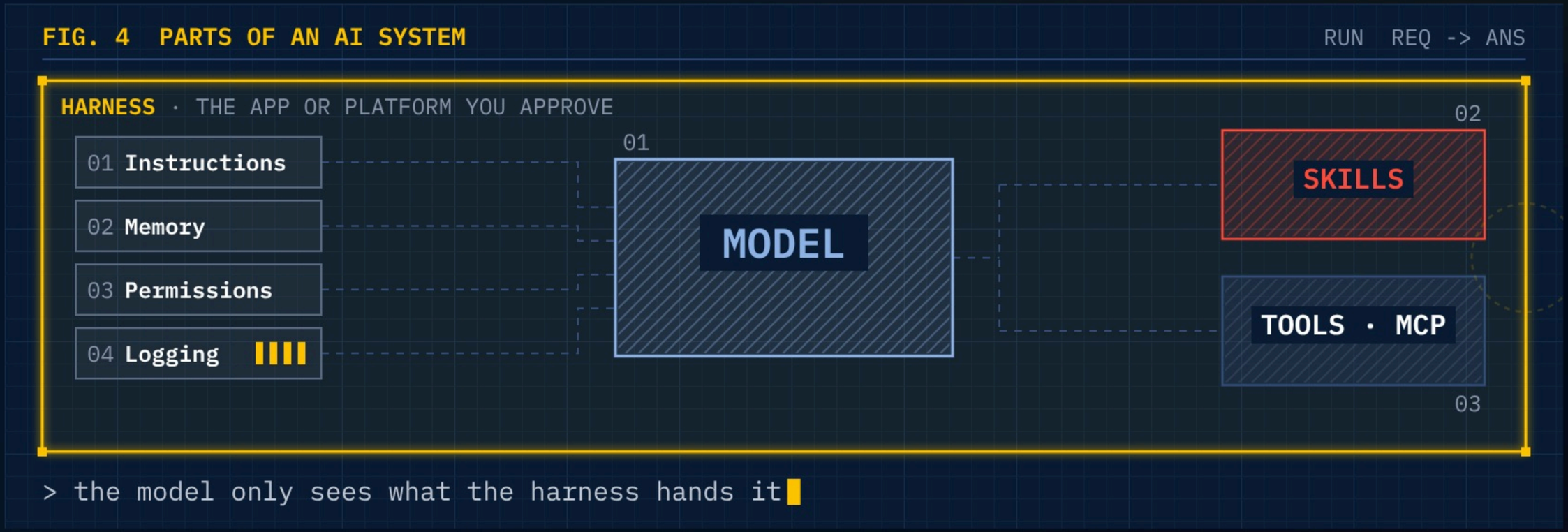
The model thinks.
Skills teach it how.
Tools let it act.
The harness decides which of those it gets.

An API lets your own software reach the model directly, which makes that software the harness.

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THE PARTS OF AN AI SYSTEM

The harness wraps everything else

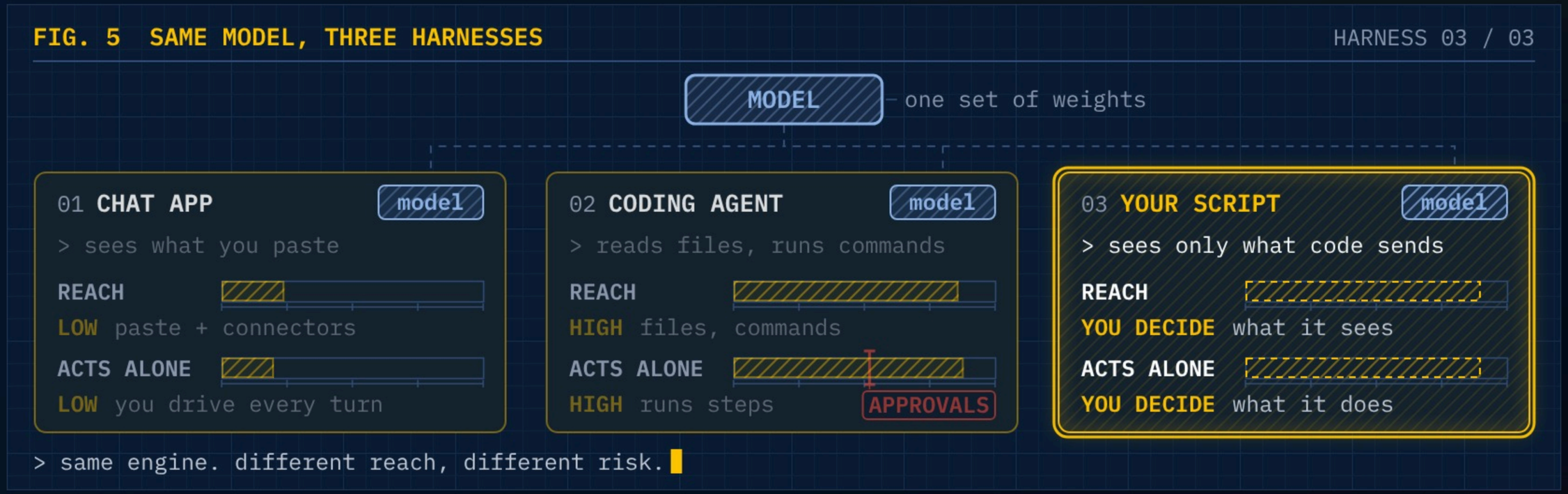


API Software calls the model directly. Your code becomes the harness, and your team owns its controls.

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SAME MODEL, DIFFERENT HARNESS

Identical engine. Different reach, different risk.



That is why security approves the harness, not just the model.

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TYPES OF HARNESSES

Six kinds your learners will meet

Chat assistants

Claude.ai · ChatGPT · Gemini app

A conversation, uploads, optional search

Built into tools

Email · docs · tickets · case systems

Works on data already in that app

Org platforms

Your approved platform or gateway

Many models, one front door, logged

Coding and agent tools

Claude Code · Codex CLI · Gemini CLI

Read files, run commands, loop to a goal

Open-source agents

OpenClaw · Hermes Agent

Self-hosted, any model, supply-chain risk

Your own software

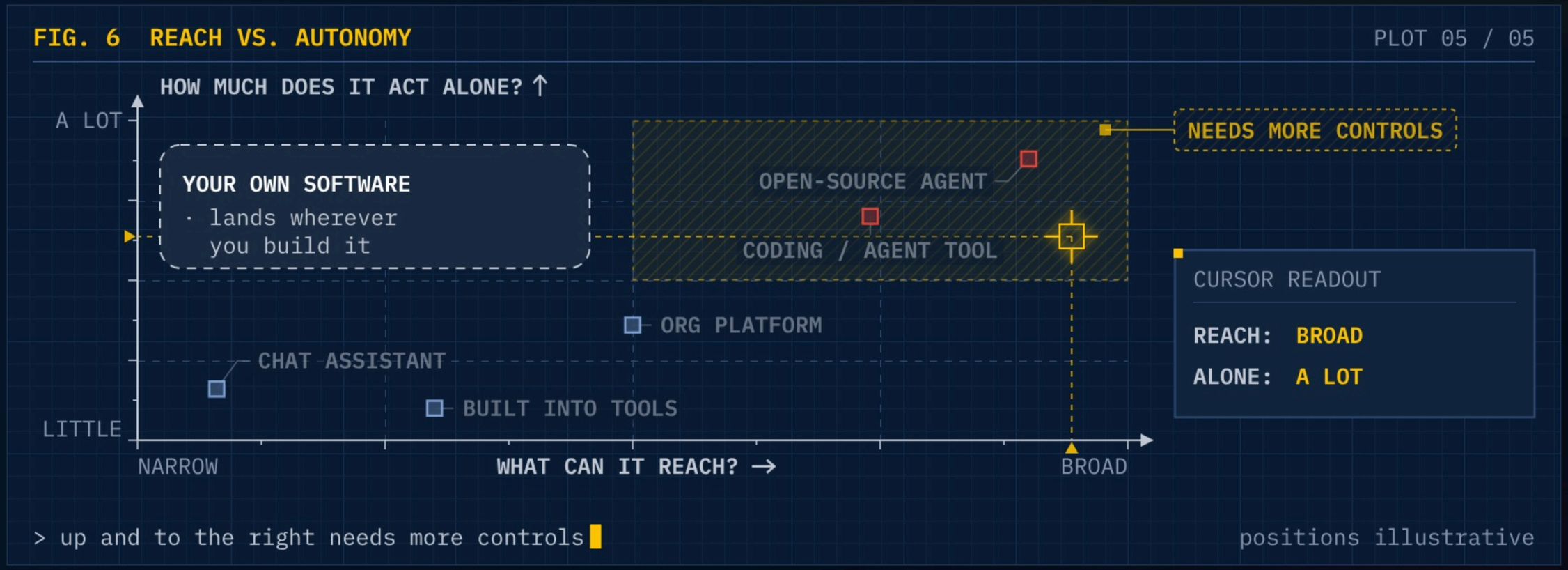
Scripts · low-code flows · agent SDKs

Calls the model by API; you are the harness

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COMPARING HARNESS TYPES

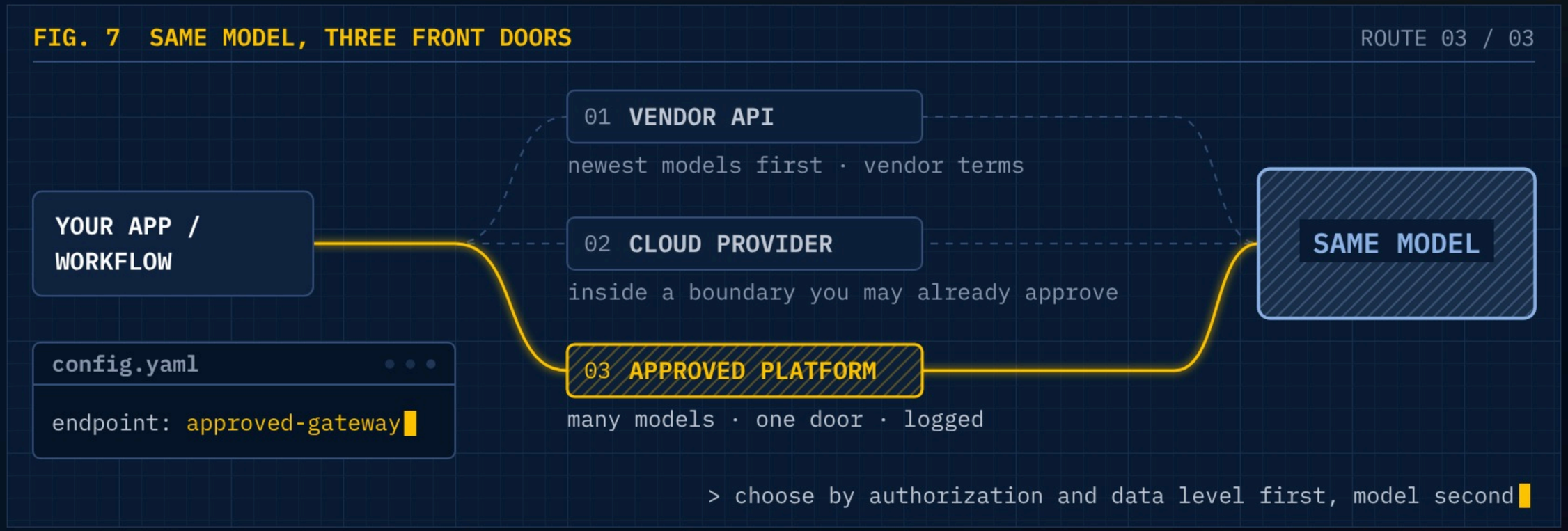
Ask two questions of any harness: what can it reach, and how much does it act alone?



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WHERE THE API COMES FROM

Same model, three front doors



Choose by authorization and data level first, model second. Keep the endpoint in config so a switch is one line.

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CHATBOT, WORKFLOW, AGENT

Three different things: who picks each step?

Chatbot



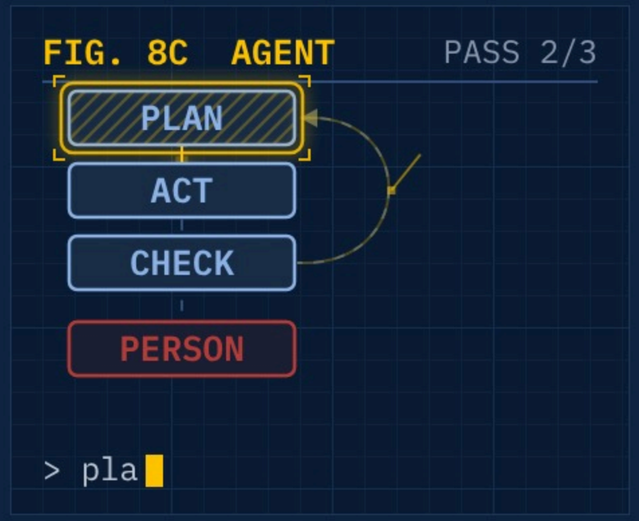
Decides: the person, each message
Risk: wrong answer taken as fact

Workflow



Decides: a designer, in advance
Risk: breaks quietly when inputs change

Agent

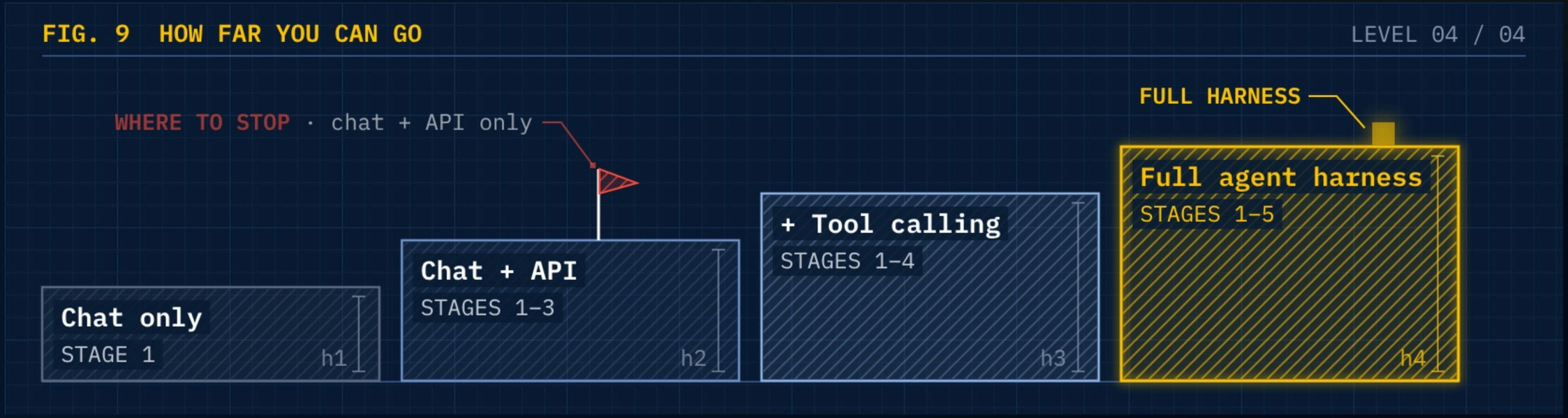


Decides: the AI, at run time
Risk: mistakes compound across steps

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WHAT YOUR ENVIRONMENT ALLOWS

Your approved harness sets how far you go



Where to stop: chat-and-API teams stop at Stage 3 and still get working, containerized automation.

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EXERCISE

Sort the tasks, then inventory a harness

Pause & try

A Chatbot, workflow or agent?

1 Reply to one customer email CHATBOT

2 Summarize every weekly status report to one inbox WORKFLOW

3 Find expiring contracts; draft renewal notices AGENT

4 Explain a new regulation in plain language CHATBOT

5 Extract invoice fields to a sheet, nightly WORKFLOW

6 Find why a nightly report failed; propose a fix AGENT

7 Brainstorm names for a new project CHATBOT

8 Translate every incoming form and file it WORKFLOW

9 Research three vendors across many sites AGENT

10 Rewrite a paragraph for a senior audience CHATBOT

B Harness inventory

Pick one AI tool your team uses:

1. Which of the six types?
2. Which models sit behind it?
3. What can it reach?
4. How much does it act alone?
5. Who approved it, for what data?

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CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING

Can every learner answer these?

1

In one sentence, what is a large language model?

2

Why can the same model be safe in one app and risky in another?

3

Does the model learn from your chats? What is “memory,” then?

4

Name three types of harness and an example of each.

5

Who picks each step in a chatbot, a workflow and an agent?

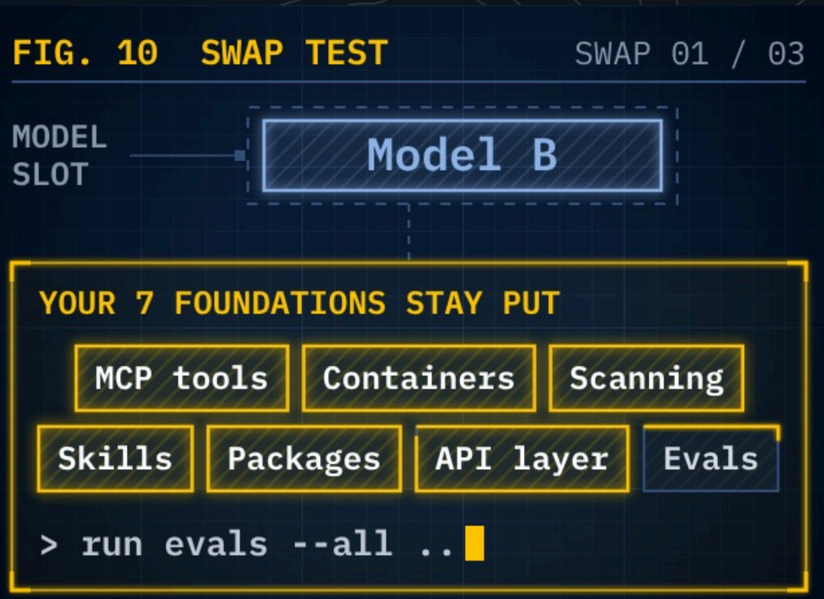
6

When would you choose a workflow over an agent?

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NEXT · SESSION 2 · AI RESILIENCE

If models and harnesses are replaceable, what must your organization own?



Seven foundations that keep you agnostic

- Approved MCP tools
- Containers
- Scanning
- Skills
- Approved packages
- Multi-vendor API framework
- Stored evals